

CASE ID: 201602710713

EPISODE NAME: China sanctions Taiwan following Tsai Election

2016/02/23 - 2026/01/17

Sender: China (710)

Target: Taiwan (713)

Issue: Solve Territorial Dispute (5)

Final Outcome: Stalemate after Sanctions Imposition (9)

Summary:

On 2016/02/23, Beijing curbed tourism between China and Taiwan in the wake of the island's 2016 election of the Democratic Progressive Party's Tsai Ing-wen, who held a less acquiescent stance on China than the previous administration.¹ Further, on 2016/06/25, China suspended diplomatic contact with Taiwan after Tsai's inauguration.² On 2026/01/17, China began to ease tourism restrictions between the two nations.³ Diplomatic relations have not recovered.

Narrative:

On 2016/02/23, reports emerged that Beijing had begun restricting tourism between Taiwan and China.⁴ China instituted new travel policies that discouraged Chinese citizens from visiting Taiwan, and limited the number of Chinese cities Taiwanese citizens could visit.⁵

The tourism restrictions were in response to Taiwan's election of China-skeptic presidential candidate Tsai Ing-wen, the leader of the Democratic Progressive Party (DPP), on 2016/01/16.⁶ The country also decisively elected a majority-DPP parliament for the first time, significantly curtailing the power of the Kuomintang (KMT), a party more willing to appease China.⁷

¹ Shim, Elizabeth. "China restricting tourism to Taiwan after election." *United Press International*, 23 Feb. 2016. https://www.upi.com/Top_News/World-News/2016/02/23/China-restricting-tourism-to-Taiwan-after-elections/1471456255035/

² Hernández, Javier. "China Suspends Diplomatic Contact With Taiwan." *The New York Times*, June 25th, 2016. <https://www.nytimes.com/2016/06/26/world/asia/china-suspends-diplomatic-contact-with-taiwan.html>.

³ Lu, Alan. "China to resume Taiwan tour groups amid blame game." *Radio Free Asia*, 17 Jan. 2026. <https://www.rfa.org/english/china/2025/01/17/china-taiwan-group-tour-shanghai/>

⁴ Shim, Elizabeth. "China restricting tourism to Taiwan after election." *United Press International*, 23 Feb. 2016. https://www.upi.com/Top_News/World-News/2016/02/23/China-restricting-tourism-to-Taiwan-after-elections/1471456255035/

⁵ *Ibid.*

⁶ Ramsey, Austin. "Tsai Ing-wen Elected President of Taiwan, First Woman to Hold Office." *New York Times*, 16 Jan. 2016. <https://www.nytimes.com/2016/01/17/world/asia/taiwan-elections.html>.

⁷ Meick, Ethan, and O'Connor, Sean. "Taiwan Opposition Party Wins Presidency and Legislative Majority in Historic Elections." *U.S.-China Economic and Security Review Commission*, January 28th, 2016. https://www.uscc.gov/sites/default/files/Research/Taiwan%20s%20Elections%20Issue%20Brief_0.pdf.

From 2016/05/20 to 2016/12, tourism from China to Taiwan dropped 36.2 percent.⁸ China denied this as an official sanction, despite multiple outlets reporting the most significant decrease started immediately after Tsai Ing-wen took power in May.⁹

On 2016/06/25, China suspended official diplomatic communication with Taiwan due to Tsai's refusal to acknowledge the "one China" policy, which asserts that Taiwan is part of mainland China.¹⁰

The episode ended on 2026/01/17, when China began to reopen tourism between the countries.¹¹ Diplomatic relations have not been restored.

⁸ "Taiwan says China tourists down 36.2 percent amid political tension." *Reuters*, December 29th, 2016. <https://www.reuters.com/article/lifestyle/taiwan-says-china-tourists-down-362-percent-amid-political-tension-idUSKBN14I0YN>.

⁹ *Ibid.*

¹⁰ Hernández, Javier. "China Suspends Diplomatic Contact With Taiwan." *The New York Times*, June 25th, 2016. <https://www.nytimes.com/2016/06/26/world/asia/china-suspends-diplomatic-contact-with-taiwan.html>.

¹¹ Lu, Alan. "China to resume Taiwan tour groups amid blame game." *Radio Free Asia*, 17 Jan. 2026. <https://www.rfa.org/english/china/2025/01/17/china-taiwan-group-tour-shanghai/>